



INTERMEDIATE PATHWAY · 15 WEEKS

The Arab Renaissance

A Sample 15-Week Pathway · Designed for Marwan, age 13

PROGRAMME OVERVIEW

Marwan, a 13-year-old with severe dyslexia, feels intimidated by reading and assignments in his middle school history course on the Arab Renaissance (the Nahda). This pathway is designed to meet his specific learning needs by integrating creative and interactive activities with adapted readings. Marwan's tutor will guide him through primary sources, visual materials, and practical projects that sustain his engagement and develop his intellectual potential and confidence. At the end of the 15-week pathway, Marwan and his tutor will compile a portfolio containing all of the project materials and exercises he has undertaken. This will provide Marwan with a tangible overview of his newfound knowledge and skills and allow him to reflect on his personal and intellectual growth. The pathway will culminate in a final project that ties together Marwan's newly acquired knowledge and skills.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Content

- Understanding historical context in the nineteenth-century Arab world; why did the Nahda's intellectuals seek change?
- Discovering how education, language, and communication became tools for social progress
- Getting to know the Nahda movement's principal personalities
- Tracing features of modern Arab culture and societies back to nineteenth-century developments

Skills

- Learning to think like a historian by analysing different types of sources (books, newspapers, letters, and images)
- Developing verbal reasoning skills through critical conversation and presentations
- Honing persuasive and reflective writing skills through regular essays and assignments
- Cultivating visual analysis skills

POSSIBLE FINAL PROJECTS

- Designing a Nahda Newspaper featuring the key figures, ideas, and events of the period
- An oral presentation tracing modern features of Arab society and culture back to the Nahda
- Writing a biographical essay explaining one key Nahda figure's contributions
- Designing an interactive museum display about the Nahda, including artefacts and explanations
- Creating a short video exploring the Nahda's visual legacy (art, architecture, etc.)

WEEKLY PATHWAY

Week 1 Historical Context – What Was the Arab World Like in 1800?

- Introducing key vocabulary: nahda, revival, modernisation, etc.
- What does it mean for a culture to have a “renaissance” or revival?
- Map exploration: The Ottoman Empire and Arab regions in 1800
- Comparing key features of daily life to the modern day (transportation, communication, education, etc.)
- What challenges did Arab societies face in the early nineteenth century?
- How did people communicate news and ideas without modern technology?
- Why might some people have wanted to ‘revive’ Arab society while others sought to sustain tradition?

Exercise

Creating a mindmap visually demonstrating the key features of the Arab world in 1800 and forming connections between different ideas and developments.

Weeks 2–3 The Power of Language – Reviving Arabic Literature and Writing

- Excerpts from al-Bustani's speeches on Arabic literature
- Examples of classical Arabic poetry vs. new Nahda writing styles
- Headlines from early Arabic newspapers

- Introductory discussion on Butrus al-Bustani and the Arabic language
- Why did the Nahda's thinkers care so much about the Arabic language?
- How can language be a source of cultural pride?
- Can you identify examples of differences between classical and modern Arabic writing styles?

Exercise

Comparing an old Arabic poem with a modern Arabic song – what similarities and differences do you observe in tone, word choice, and sentence structure?

Weeks 4–5 Opening Minds – The Revolution in Education and Schools

- Excerpts from Al-Tahtawi's descriptions of schools in Paris
- Stories about the first modern schools in Egypt and Lebanon
- Letters from parents discussing whether to send children to new vs. traditional schools
- What was education like in the Arab world before the Nahda? Who was able to go to school?
- Why did some people oppose new teaching methods while others supported them?
- How did travel to Europe influence Arab ideas about education?
- What subjects do you think were the most important additions to Arab schools in the nineteenth century?

Exercise

Designing the ideal school curriculum for the nineteenth century – what subjects would you include and why?

Weeks 6–7 Spreading Ideas – The Birth of Arabic Journalism and Publishing

- Front pages from early Arabic newspapers like Hadiqat al-Akhbar
- Advertisements for new books and educational materials
- Debates in newspapers about social issues
- How did newspapers help foster a sense of community among Arab readers?

- What kinds of news and information did people want to read about?
- How did printing presses change how knowledge was shared and who was able to access this knowledge?
- What were the most important debates taking place in Arab newspapers?

Exercise

Create your own nineteenth-century Arabic newspaper page, including news stories, advertisements, and opinion pieces that reflect Nahda concerns. Use historical events, but write in your own words.

Weeks 8–9 Bridging Worlds – Translation and Cultural Exchange

- Examples of European books translated into Arabic during the Nahda
- Stories of Arab students who travelled to study in Europe
- Debates about what ideas to adopt and what to reject from other cultures
- Why was translation such an important part of the Nahda?
- How did Arab intellectuals decide what foreign ideas were useful and which ones to avoid or reject?
- What challenges did Arab students face when studying abroad?
- Why might Arab societies have been sceptical of engaging with foreign cultures and traditions?

Exercise

Choose one book that was translated into Arabic during the Nahda. Research what it was about and why it was considered important and relevant to Arab society. Present your findings and explain whether you think it was a good choice for translation.

Weeks 10–11 Women's Voices in the Nahda

- Excerpts from women's writings about education and social change
- Stories about the first girls' schools and women's magazines
- Letters between women intellectuals discussing their ideas
- What challenges did women face in participating in the Nahda?
- What bold and creative methods did women use to overcome these challenges?

- How did women contribute to debates about education and social progress?
- What arguments did women make about their roles in society?

Exercise

Write a letter from the perspective of a young Arab woman in the 1890s to her friend, discussing her hopes for education and social change. Base your letter on the real experiences of women from this period.

Weeks 12–13 Building Modern Societies – Political Ideas and Social Change

- Excerpts from political writings about governance and rights
- Stories about the founding of famous institutions (Syrian Protestant College, Egyptian Museum, National Library of Egypt)
- Photo comparisons of Cairo, Beirut, and Damascus before and after Nahda developments
- Accounts of how ordinary families' lives changed when new schools, hospitals, and libraries opened
- Stories about the first public parks, gas lighting, and modern streets in Arab cities
- Letters from children describing their new schools compared to traditional education
- What did Nahda thinkers mean when they talked about “freedom” and “progress”?
- How did people organise themselves to create change in their communities?
- What role did religion play in discussions about modernising society?
- How did different Arab regions approach instigating change?

Exercise

Choose the Arab city which you think underwent the most radical changes to its institutions and culture during the Nahda. Create a timeline of these changes, and use a combination of before and after photos and written explanations to argue your case.

Weeks 14–15 The Nahda's Legacy – How These Ideas Shaped the Modern Arab World

- Examples of modern Arab institutions (universities, newspapers, cultural centres) that can be traced back to the Nahda

- Excerpts from biographies of modern Arab intellectuals who built on the Nahda's foundations
- Comparative texts on nineteenth-century vs. contemporary debates about education, language, and cultural identity in the Arab world
- Which of the Nahda's ideals are most important and enduring in Arab societies today, and why?
- How do you interpret the balance between tradition and Arab modernity in the Arab world today?
- How has the Arabic language continued to develop since the Nahda period?
- How has studying the Nahda changed your understanding of the Arab world?
- If there were another Nahda today, what would its main principles and ideas be?

Exercise

Write about which Nahda figure you found most inspiring and why. How might their ideas apply to challenges facing young people today?